

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**

underbanked. All this has also allowed 'direct benefit transfers' to over 900 million citizens.

A dark side to this digital identity dependence: denial of benefits. A national survey after the 2019 election found that 39 per cent of poorer households had been denied subsidised rations due to Aadhaar problems. In March 2021, the Supreme Court issued a notice to the Centre on a plea alleging cancellation of around 40 million ration cards due to non-linking with Aadhaar cards, resulting in starvation deaths.

At the core of the digital economy are digital payments. The government-backed direction is centred on mobile and UPI, and away from cash and even from cards. The RBI's 2025 vision includes "a less-cash, less-card society". And so, despite the billion-plus debit and credit cards issued in India, what's driving payment volumes and stretching the banking system is India's UPI payment system from NPCI, powering over 250 million UPI transactions each day. While India's digital payment volume has grown over 50 per cent a year over the past five years, UPI volumes grew 160 per cent annually. Inevitably, so did fraud: nearly 150,000 incidents of UPI fraud were reported on the home ministry's cybercrime portal in just the first half of last year, over 15 per cent of all cybercrime complaints.

Inspired by the success of Aadhaar, UPI and other digital programmes, the Modi government has moved on to building other mega platforms. CoWIN, quickly put together for the Covid vaccine, helped administer over two billion shots, and is evolving into a vaccination platform beyond Covid. The associated Arogya Setu 'Covid app' will become a health app.

Other mega platforms ramping up in 2023 include the new ONDC, or One Network for Digital Commerce, which aims to reduce dependence on foreign-owned e-commerce platforms. Then there's National Digital Educational Architecture, or NDEAR, for a sector that moved online with a vengeance in the pandemic. But the real biggie in 2023 will be in health.

The Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission, aimed at universal health coverage, will store the health data of 1.4 billion Indians. Linked to Aadhaar, it will contain all historical records, a network of doctors and medical service providers, a linked registry of drugs, allowing data-sharing across healthcare providers and doctors, "with the consent of patients".

So, will you consent? You may not know it, but you possibly already have an Ayushman Bharat health account number. It was reported that over 170 million such accounts were created, most without the knowledge of the patient—and likely when they signed up on CoWIN for the Covid vaccine, or for a national insurance scheme called PMJAY.

So let's park consent for now. Six years after the Supreme Court declared privacy a fundamental right in 2017, we don't have a privacy law yet. That could change in 2023 with the Digital Personal Data Protection Bill, but the draft bill appears to focus more on data protection than privacy, exempts government agencies from some of the controls and checks, and excludes information not collected or processed digitally (the 'digital' in its name also makes the point).